magazines, it was the sign of a reporter having access to hard news. And that was it.

Next, he called Verma. He came on the line immediately. Upon hearing what Anirudhya had learnt, Verma paused briefly to respond. ‘Maybe you should call the boss and tell him. He would know you are resourceful and not just dependent on his team.’

Anirudhya said he already had, thinking his friend was referring to *India Today*’s editor-in-chief and publisher Aroon Purie. But Verma had meant his boss, Kaarthikeyan. He said he would drop in that night and disconnected the call.

Anirudhya sat on stacks of newspaper clippings, all of which were about ‘who’ could have killed Rajiv Gandhi. One newspaper wrote, ‘PETN was used to kill Rajiv.’ The report quoted a witness who claimed to have watched Rajiv approach the dais when a woman came forward and fished out a bomb that was detonated by another woman with a remote control. But a senior Congress leader had denied it in the same report.

The Hindu had accessed a Colombo-based report that quoted Sri Lankan government officials who claimed that ‘the LTTE was behind the assassination’ and that similar tactics had been used to blow a special task force patrol in Batticaloa two months ago. They produced proof of the use of a radio-type remote-control device to set off that explosion.[3]

Another article that caught Anirudhya’s attention claimed that the ‘assassin was a guest of Congress leader Maragatham Chandrasekar’, who had stayed in her house before the assassination. Anirudhya felt it was a new twist in the case. The next was even more intriguing, which blamed the SIT: ‘Attempts to suppress the identity of the assassin.’ Then another report claimed ‘the CIA’s hand behind the dastardly assassination’, since Rajiv Gandhi was clearly emerging as the next Prime Minister, which was not in America’s interests.

Anirudhya called Kanth at the SIT and asked if they were aware of the rampant speculation in the media. The latter said they were, and the problem was that they could not ‘ignore’ any such report. ‘The SIT has to get all such claims verified,’ he said. ‘I guess most of it is to sell news.’